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LAYLAT AL QADR OBSERVED AT SHAIKH ZAYED GRAND MOSQUE

Thousands of worshippers gathered for prayer at Shaikh Zayed Grand Mosque in Abu Dhabi on Wednesday to observe Laylat Al Qadr, also known as the Night of Power, a significant night in the Islamic calendar. This night, falling during the last ten days of Ramadan, holds substantial spiritual importance for Muslims and is marked by special prayers, reflections, and seeking divine blessings.

SEE ALSO P4

New symbol for dirham unveiled

Move aligns with UAE joining FX Global Code, progress in digital dirham initiative

DUBAI
BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor



The Central Bank of the UAE (CBUAE) unveiled a new symbol for the country's national currency, the dirham, as part of efforts to strengthen the UAE's position as a global financial hub.

The new dirham symbol, derived from the English letter "D," includes two horizontal lines representing financial sta-

bility and is inspired by the UAE flag. It will be used internationally to promote the UAE's currency in global markets.

Additionally, the digital dirham — the digital version of the currency — will feature a circular design incorporating the UAE flag's colours to symbolise national pride and modern financial evolution.

The CBUAE also provided updates on the digital dirham

which is expected to roll out in late 2025 for the retail sector.

Licensed financial institutions, including banks, exchange houses, finance companies, and fintech firms, will facilitate access to the digital dirham. It will be legally recognised as a universal payment method alongside physical currency. The digital dirham will drive innovation and financial inclusion, including:

■ **Tokenisation:** Enabling fractional ownership of digital assets, improving liquidity.

■ **Smart Contracts:** Allowing automated execution of complex financial transactions, ensuring instant settlement and compliance with predefined conditions.

Gazans rally for an end to Hamas rule

ISRAELI AIR STRIKE KILLS ONE OF GROUP'S OFFICIAL SPOKESMEN

GAZA CITY

Thousands of Palestinians demonstrated across parts of the Gaza Strip Wednesday in rare protests against militant group Hamas, the ruler of the war-ravaged territory.

Yesterday, Hamas said an Israeli air strike killed one of its official spokesmen in Gaza, the latest high-ranking operative targeted since Israel resumed its bombardment.

The group said in a statement it mourned the loss of Abdul Latif Al Qanou who was killed in what it called a "direct" strike on a tent he was in, in the Jabalia area of northern Gaza.

Meanwhile, demonstrations began in Beit Lahiya in the north on Tuesday, before spreading to Gaza City and central Gaza a day later. Protesters called on Hamas to relinquish control of Gaza and end the 18-month war with Israel that's killed tens of thousands of people. "The protest was spontaneous; it stemmed from the oppression we live under," one of the demonstrators, Rezek Salem, said on phone from Beit Lahiya.

First time

This is the first time crowds have openly called on Hamas to step aside and sustained protests into a second day. The demonstrations against Hamas have

The demonstrations began in Beit Lahiya in the north on Tuesday, before spreading to Gaza City and central Gaza a day later.

been largely peaceful, with the militant group's police and security forces rarely appearing in public. Hamas and its allied factions said the demonstrations should focus on ending the war and getting Israel to reopen border crossings to allow more aid into the Palestinian territory. They also warned of an Israeli "scheme" aimed at exploiting the protests to sow divisions among Palestinians.

Israel's Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said the rallies showed his country was succeeding in weakening Hamas's political power. His defence minister, Israel Katz, said more Gazans should take to the streets.

"We saw something that we've never seen in the past," Netanyahu said to the Israeli parliament. "We saw large, open protests against Hamas. The Gazans understand that Hamas has brought upon them destruction."

According to the health ministry in Hamas-run Gaza, at least 855 people have been killed since March 18.

— Agencies
SEE ALSO P9



FRIDAY

Gifting ideas, home décor trends & more, in our Friday magazine's Eid edition. The WEEKENDER will return next week



IFTAR 18:37

Fajr	04:57	Shuruq	06:11
Dhuhr	12:27	Asr	15:53
Maghrib	18:37	Isha	19:51

IMSAK 04:47

Add 4 minutes for Abu Dhabi, deduct 4 minutes for RAK and 6 minutes for Fujairah

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